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Socio-Economic Status of Tribal Women: A Case Study of Gumla District, Jharkhand

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Abstract: The study examines the socio-economic status of tribal women in Gumla district, Jharkhand, using primary data collected from 120 respondents across four villages of Bishunpur block using pre-designed questionnaire by interview method. The research focuses on the analysis of various socio-economic indicators such as literacy and education, health and nutrition, employment, income, and access to bank accounts. The findings clearly indicate low literacy levels among tribal women, with none of the respondents having completed a graduate level education. Although most women have a normal BMI, health awareness and access to medical facilities are limited. Employment is largely confined to agriculture and informal sectors, resulting in low-income levels. And although most of the respondents have bank accounts, active usage and financial literacy remain moderate. The study highlights the persistent socio-economic inequalities faced by tribal women and emphasizes the need for targeted interventions in education, healthcare, skill development, and financial inclusion.

Keywords: Tribal women, Education, Nutrition, Employment, Income, Financial Inclusion.

1. Introduction

The socio-cultural landscape of India is greatly influenced by tribal communities. These ethnic communities are protected and acknowledged by the Indian Constitution under the Scheduled Tribes category (Article 366[25]), which is defined in Article 342 by a Presidential notification **(Suresh, 2019)**. These indigenous groups are commonly referred to as indigenous peoples or

Adivasis. According to the World Bank, indigenous peoples' identities, ways of livelihood, and cultural practices are inseparable from the land they live on **(World Bank, 2025)**. The United Nations also highlights that these groups have distinct perspectives on society and the environment **(United Nation, n.d.)**. According to the 2011 Census of India, Scheduled Tribes constitute about 104.3 million people, representing 8.6 percent of India's overall population. The vast bulk of this people (89.97 Percent) resides in rural areas and depends largely on land and natural resources for their livelihoods **(Honnurswamy & Panduranga, 2014)**. When it comes to its tribal population, Jharkhand is a particularly important state in India. Jharkhand is home to 32 different tribal groups out of the 705 declared tribes in the nation, making approximately 26.2 percent of the state's total population. The Santhal, Oraon, and Kharia are the major communities in Jharkhand, along with eight Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs). These PVTG groups are identified by extremely low literacy rates, pre-agricultural technology, and stagnant or declining populations **(Honnurswamy & Panduranga, 2014)**. The language, customs, and social and cultural activities of these tribal communities are all distinct. Despite this variation, the majority of tribes deal with comparable issues including health, educational access, and economic growth. Tribal communities in Jharkhand have been historically denied access to resources and opportunities, and unless government commitments are implemented effectively on the ground, significant change is unlikely **(Kumar, 2008)**.

Women play a vital role in tribal communities, both within their households and in their communities as a whole. Tribal groups in India prefer to provide women a comparatively high social status, in contrast to many other patriarchal communities. However, the contributions of women to household management, cultural life, and agricultural labour are not highly appreciated in any community. Although tribal women are viewed as contributing members of their communities in theory, in reality, their socioeconomic circumstances are still quite poor when compared to those of both men and women from other social groups. They have to face dual disadvantages of being a woman and belonging to a marginalised community. A number of interconnected issues, such as geographic geographical isolation, poverty, illiteracy, lack of access to healthcare, and low political engagement, hinder their socioeconomic development.

The general growth of a society has been shown to be significantly influenced by the socioeconomic standing of women. It is assessed using a number of metrics, including household decision-making authority, employment, income, health, and education. The socio-

economic backwardness of tribal women is reflected in several indicators. In Jharkhand, tribal women's literacy rate is considerably lower at 46.2 percent, while tribal men's is 68.2 percent (Census 2011). Similarly, according to NFHS-5 (2019–21), women from other social groups have much more access to assets than tribal women do. Although literacy among scheduled tribes has improved over time, the rates in Jharkhand remain lower than the national average, with many welfare programmes failing to reach the intended beneficiaries effectively **(Honnurswamy & Panduranga, 2014)**. Employment statistics, as reported by the Periodic Labour Force Survey (2018-19), further demonstrate the disparities. Most tribal women remain engaged in the unorganized sector, particularly agriculture and informal labour. While urban tribal workers find limited opportunities in the formal tertiary sector, a majority are absorbed in informal employment such as agriculture and construction **(Kumar & Baraik, 2022)**. Seasonal migration further exacerbates their socio-economic insecurity **(Deogharia, 2012)**. Low literacy levels, poor health status, lack of employment opportunities, adherence to traditional beliefs, lower political participation, and technological backwardness are major obstacles in the development of tribal women **(Binjha, 2020)**.

Gumla district offers a unique context for examining the socio-economic status of tribal women in the state of Jharkhand. 68.94 percent of district population belongs to Scheduled Tribes, making it one of the most tribal-dominated districts in the state. The major communities include the Oraon (62.63 Percent), Munda (11.70 Percent), Kharia (9.07 Percent), and Lohra (5.77 Percent). While rich in natural resources and cultural traditions, Gumla also suffers from socio-economic backwardness. Low literacy rates, lack of diverse employment opportunities, poor infrastructure, and limited access to healthcare have hampered development outcomes in the district. Given the overwhelming dominance of tribal communities in the population, Gumla's socio-economic development is inseparable from the development of its tribal women. While macro-level statistics shed light on widespread inequalities, they often fail to uncover the micro-realities of women's lives in tribal-dominated areas. There is a clear research gap in micro-level, primary data-based studies assessing the socio-economic status of tribal women in specific regions of Jharkhand. By filling this gap, the current study aims to provide current insights into the socio-economic status of tribal women and contribute to more context-sensitive policymaking. The present study seeks to assess the socio-economic status of tribal women in Gumla district of Jharkhand, using primary data. The study aims to analyze key

indicators such as education, health, employment, ownership of assets and income to understand both opportunities and challenges faced by tribal women in Gumla district.

1.1. Objectives of the Study

The primary objective of the present paper is to assess the current socio-economic status of the tribal women in Gumla district of Jharkhand. The specific objectives are:

1. To assess the literacy and educational status of tribal women in Gumla district of Jharkhand.
2. To assess the nutritional and health status of tribal women in Gumla district of Jharkhand.
3. To assess the employment status of tribal women in Gumla district of Jharkhand.
4. To assess the income status of tribal women in Gumla district of Jharkhand.
5. To analyze the financial inclusion among the tribal women in Gumla district of Jharkhand.
6. To suggest policy measures for improving the socio-economic status of tribal women in Gumla district.

1.2. Material and Methods

Data Collection: The study is based primarily on primary data, collected through a structured questionnaire designed in accordance with the objectives. Although, wherever necessary, secondary sources such as Census 2011, NFHS-5, PLFS reports, and publications of the Ministry of Tribal Affairs have been used.

Study Area and sampling design: The present study has been undertaken in Gumla district of Jharkhand, which has been purposively selected on account of its substantial tribal population (68.94 Percent as per Census 2011). A multi-stage random sampling method was adopted for the selection of respondents. In the first stage, among the twelve blocks of Gumla district, Bishunpur block was selected as it records the highest proportion of tribal population (around 95 Percent). In the second stage, four villages from Bishunpur block were selected on the basis of their relative concentration of tribal population. Finally, at the household level, a random selection was carried out, and from each selected household, one tribal woman respondent was interviewed. In total, 120 respondents were interviewed to assess the various indicators of socio-economic status of tribal women of Gumla district.

Data analysis: The primary data were analyzed using descriptive statistical tools, including tables, charts, frequency, percentages, means to examine literacy, education, health, employment, income, and financial inclusion.

Scope and Limitations: The study focusses on the socio-economic status of tribal women and is confined to the Gumla district in Jharkhand. Because of regional and cultural differences between various tribal communities, these findings while useful in providing information about their socioeconomic circumstances, but may not be generalised to the entire state. However, the micro-level evidence of the study is anticipated to contribute to the discourse on the growth of tribal women in similar contexts in Jharkhand.

2. Results and discussion:

The present study aimed to understand the multiple dimensions of the social and economic status of tribal women. Age structure, family types, literacy, education, health, occupation, nature of employment, income and access to banks of the respondents are the primary characteristics to analyze the current socio-economic status of tribal women.

Table 1: Demographic profile of respondents

Factors	Scaling	No. of Respondents	No. of Respondents (in Percent)
Age Groups	**18-25**	12	10
	26-40	75	62.5
	41-60	33	27.5
	Total	120	100.00
Family Type	**Nuclear**	84	70
	Joint	36	30
	Total	120	100.00
Marital Status	**Married**	108	90
	Unmarried	12	10
	Total	120	100.00

Source: Primary Field Survey, 2025

The data in Table 1 shows that in 120 respondents (Tribal women), 10 percent respondents are from 18-25 age group, 62.5 percent are from 26-40 age group and 27.5 percent are belong from 41-60 age group.

The size of the family and the respondent's socioeconomic status typically have an inverse relationship **(Rao & Rao, 2010)**. The majority (70 Percent) of the respondents belong to nuclear family and 30Percent of respondents belong to joint families. Another social indicator of women's socioeconomic status is their marital status. The tribal community's early marriage system has been one of its key features. Women's status is altered by marriage. Additionally, it changes the role of women and adds to their responsibilities and workload. Out of 120 respondents, 90 Percent are married, 10 Percent are unmarried (as shown in Table 1).

2.1. Educational status of tribal women

For the underprivileged people, literacy and education are powerful instruments for social and economic growth. In terms of literacy and education, tribal women are less educated than women from other social groups. This disparity is further pronounced among indigenous women, who have the lowest literacy rates in the country **(Mula & Mundu, 2024)**.

Table 2: Literacy and educational attainment of the respondents

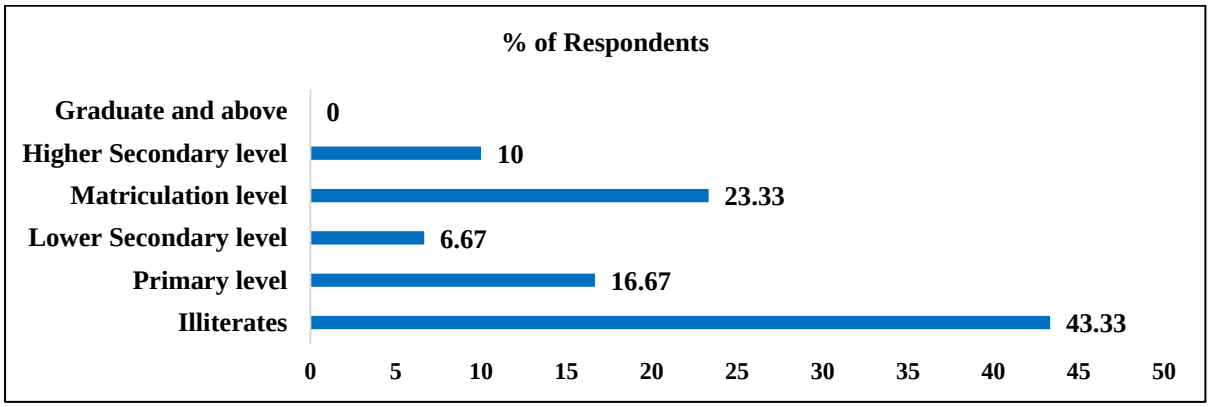
Educational Level	No. of Respondents	Percent of Respondents
Illiterates	52	43.33
Primary level	20	16.67
Lower Secondary level	8	6.67
Matriculation level	28	23.33
Higher Secondary level	12	10.00
Graduate and above	0	0.00
Total	**120**	**100.00**

Source: Primary Field Survey, 2025

It is observed from Table 2 that, the literacy rate among the respondents was 56.67 percent. Out of 120 respondents, 68 are literates and 52 are illiterates. 16.67 percent of respondents studied up to the primary level, 6.67 percent studied up to lower secondary level, and the majority (23.33 percent) of respondents are covered in the secondary level of education. The collected data reveal that none of the respondents have attained education up to the graduation level. The

main cause of this is because tribal women are typically more rooted in their traditions and hesitate to take the initiative to improve their educational standards.

Fig. 1: Educational status of respondents; Source: Primary Field Survey, 2025



2.2. Nutritional status among tribal women

Most socio-demographic factors are associated with the nutritional status of Scheduled Tribe women. Religion, place of residence, wealth status, age group, education, marital status, parity, and family size are some of the important determinants that are directly linked to the nutritional status among tribal women in India **(Biswas et al., 2022)**. Table 3 represents the nutritional status among tribal women in Gumla district of Jharkhand.

Table 3: Nutritional status of the respondents

BMI	Status	No. of Respondents	Percent of Respondents
less than 18.5	Underweight	0	0
18.5-24.9	Normal	80	66.67
25 and above	Overweight	40	33.33
	Total	120	100.00

Source: Primary Field Survey, 2025

The data on Body Mass Index (BMI) of the respondents indicate that none of the tribal women were underweight, which is a positive finding. A majority of 66.67 percent of the respondents fall within the normal BMI range (18.5–24.9), reflecting generally satisfactory nutritional status. However, 33.33 percent of the respondents are overweight. During the interview, it has been found that there is a lack of awareness about health issues among the respondents and lack of health services and disease testing facilities in this tribal dominating area.

2.3. Employment status of the tribal women

"Those workers who had worked for the major part of the reference period (i.e. 6 months or more) are termed as Main Workers. Those workers who had not worked for the major part of the reference period (i.e. less than 6 months) are termed as Marginal Workers. A person who did not at all work during the reference period was treated as non-worker" **(Open Government Data (OGD) Platform India, 2018)**. The non-workers broadly constitute Students who did not participate in any economic activity paid or unpaid, household duties who were attending to daily household chores like cooking, cleaning utensils, looking after children, fetching water etc. and are not even helping in the unpaid work in the family form or cultivation, dependant such as infants or very elderly people not included in the category of worker, pensioners those who are drawing pension after retirement and are not engaged in any economic activity.

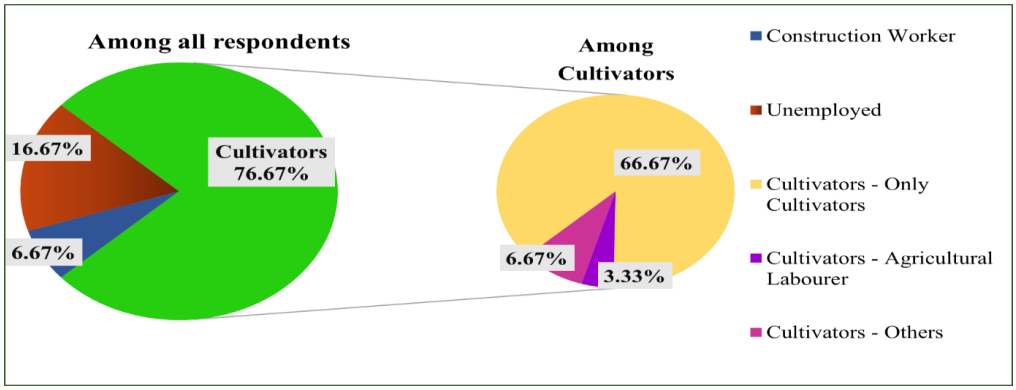
Table 4: Nature of work of respondents

Nature of Work	No. of Respondents	Percent of Respondents
Main Worker	36	30.00
Marginal Worker	76	63.33
Non-Worker	8	6.67
Total	120	100.00

Source: Primary Field Survey, 2025

Out of 120 respondents, 36.67 percent of respondents are main workers, 46.67 percent are marginal workers and 16.67 percent are non-workers. The workforce participation rate of the tribal women is 83.33 percent in the study area.

Fig. 2: Occupational structure of respondents; Source: Primary Field Survey, 2025



Among 83.33 percent of the workforce, 76.67 percent of the tribal women are cultivators, 6.67 percent are construction workers (as shown in figure 2). Among 76.67 percent of cultivators, 3.33 percent of the respondents are working as agricultural labourer as well and 6.67 percent of respondents are involved in other economic activities along with cultivation.

2.4. Income and financial inclusion among tribal women

The socio-economic status of women in any society is assessed based on their income levels and access to financial resources. This aspect is even more important for tribal women, as they generally rely heavily on limited resources, traditional livelihoods, and the unorganized sector. Their access to formal financial institutions has long been restricted, hampering their economic autonomy and decision-making. In recent years, government financial inclusion programs, such as the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY), have simplified the process of opening bank accounts in tribal areas. As a result, a large number of tribal women have joined the formal banking system. Table 5 shows the income levels of respondents in Gumla district of Jharkhand.

Table 5: Income level of Respondents

Income level of Respondents (in Rs.)	No. of Respondents	Percent of Respondents
Nil	48	40.00
Less than 5000	24	20.00
5000-10000	48	40.00
10000-20000	0	0.00
More than 20000	0	0.00
Total	120	100.00

Source: Primary Field Survey, 2025

Table 5 shows that 40 percent of the tribal women have zero income, although they are engaged in cultivation in their own agricultural land but they are not getting any monetary income. In addition, 20 percent of respondents have the income less than 5000 and 40 percent are getting Rs. 5,000 to 10,000.

Tribal women are empowered by financial inclusion, which acts as a powerful catalyst by giving them fair access to financial services and chances for socioeconomic growth. It gives them access to official financial services, empowering women to manage their money wisely.

Table 6: Financial inclusion among tribal women through bank account access

Bank Account	No. of Respondents	Percent of Respondents
Yes	116	96.67
No	4	3.33
Total	120	100.00

Source: Primary Field Survey, 2025

The data (in table 6) indicate a high level of financial inclusion among the respondents. Out of the total 120 respondents, 96.67 percent of tribal women reported having a bank account, while only 3.33 percent did not possess one. This suggests that government initiatives such as Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) and other financial inclusion schemes have been successful in reaching tribal women in the study area. However, mere possession of a bank account does not necessarily guarantee active usage; hence, further investigation is required to assess the extent of account utilization, access to credit, and financial literacy among them.

3. Conclusion and policy recommendation

The present research study used primary data collected from 120 respondents in four villages of the Bishunpur block to investigate the socio-economic status of tribal women in Gumla district, Jharkhand. The results show that tribal women still encounter a number of socio-economic obstacles. The literacy rate among the respondents is low, as none of them have completed education up to the graduation level. Even though the majority of women have normal BMIs, there is still a lack of health awareness and access to healthcare facilities. Employment is largely concentrated in agriculture and informal labor, contributing to low household income. Despite having bank accounts, the majority of women only moderately use financial services and engage in active financial engagement. Overall, the study highlights persistent disparities in various socio-economic indicators such as education, health, employment, income, and financial inclusion among tribal women, underscoring the need for targeted interventions.

Based on the study findings, the following policy measures are suggested to improve the socio-economic status of tribal women in Gumla district:

- **Educational Programs**: It is necessary to increase the access to high-quality education, especially for tribal females, by implementing adult literacy initiatives, residential schools, and college scholarships. Curricula should be culturally sensitive and include mother-tongue instruction where possible.
- **Health and Nutrition:** strengthening primary health care in tribal areas through the establishment of more healthcare centres, regular physical examinations, nutritional awareness initiatives, and mobile health units that may travel to remote villages.
- **Employment and Skill Development:** Encourage tribal women to participate in skill-building and vocational training programs that emphasise self-employment, entrepreneurship, and sustainable livelihoods.
- **Financial Inclusion:** To ensure economic independence of tribal women, it is necessary to increase their financial literacy and active use of bank accounts, encourage their participation in Self Help Groups (SHGs), and ensure access to microcredit, government schemes and digital payment systems.
- **Awareness and Empowerment:** To encourage tribal women to more actively participate in decision-making within their households and communities, awareness campaigns regarding government programs, legal rights, and social entitlements should be conducted out.

These policy measures, if effectively implemented, can contribute to reducing socio-economic disparities and fostering the holistic development of tribal women in Gumla district and similar regions of Jharkhand.

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